

7.1 User Accounts

A user account is a collection of information on yourself—the user. This container of information tells Windows what files and folders you can access, what changes you can make to the computer, and your personal preferences, such as your Desktop background or the colour theme that you use. With the help of multiple user accounts, you can share your computer with friends and family and indeed colleagues, and still have your very own files and settings. Each person can thus access the same computer but can retain a level of personalisation on how they interact with the computer and also on the data that they store on the computer. Each person accesses their user account with a user name and password.

There are three different types of accounts:

- Standard
- Administrator
- Guest

Each account type gives the user a different level of control over the computer. The standard account is the account to use for everyday computing. The administrator account provides the most control over the computer, and should only be used when necessary. The guest account is primarily for people who need temporary access to the computer. To switch between accounts you can either log off from one account and then log into another, or you can switch users—which allows you to switch accounts without logging off (a logoff demands that all your programs be closed first). To Switch User, click on Start, then click on the arrow next to the lock icon, then on Switch User. Note that you can also log off from here.

As was seen in the previous chapter, there have been some elementary changes made to the way in which Vista handles and differentiates between accounts. One of the biggest changes is that the Administrator account is switched off under Vista, by default. If you have migrated to Vista from Windows XP and if Vista determines that the Administrator account was the only account avail-